PROJECT WORTH

GROOMING AWARENESS FOR EDUCATORS

EVERY ROLE HAS INFLUENCE

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Educators shape children's lives daily. Teachers, administrators, counselors, coaches, aides, substitutes, drivers, volunteers, contractors, and support staff may all be seen as trusted adults.

That influence brings responsibility. Listening well, keeping boundaries, and acting on concerns can help protect a child.

WISCONSIN HAS TAKEN IMPORTANT STEPS. NOW WHAT?

- Wisconsin Act 200 created a felony for sexual misconduct by school staff or volunteers against pupils. Act 88 later created Wisconsin's separate grooming offense and expanded the school sexual-misconduct law.
- Act 89 requires Wisconsin schools to adopt employee/volunteer-student communication policies and provide annual employee training on grooming and professional boundary violations.

Protection becomes real when educators know the signs, keep safe boundaries, report concerns, and seek meaningful training.

KNOW THE SIGNS

Possible warning signs may include when an adult or older person:

- Seeks unusual access to a child
- Creates secrecy or private communication
- Gives excessive gifts, attention, privileges, or opportunities
- Ignores physical, emotional, or digital boundaries
- Treats one child as unusually special
- Discourages the child from speaking with trusted adults
- Protects their own reputation over the child's safety

A single behavior does not necessarily indicate grooming; context, patterns, and boundary violations matter.

BE A SAFE ADULT

Safe adults listen, respect boundaries, avoid secrecy, communicate appropriately, follow protective policies, and take concerns seriously.

Children may disclose gradually or indirectly, and behavior changes can sometimes signal distress.

Your role is not to investigate. Your role is to listen, document, report, and help the child reach support.

REPORT CONCERNS

You do not need proof before raising a concern.

Do not dismiss warning signs because the person involved is respected, trusted, helpful, well-liked, or important to the school.

Follow mandated-reporting requirements and organizational procedures. When safety is at risk, protecting the child comes before protecting an adult, school, team, program, or reputation.

SEEK MEANINGFUL TRAINING

Policies only work when adults understand how grooming develops, how disclosures may appear, and how to respond.

Children should not be expected to recognize grooming before trained adults do.

As a best practice, every child-serving organization should provide practical training on:

- Grooming and boundary violations
- Appropriate employee-student communication
- Mandated reporting
- Responding to disclosures
- Digital communication and access
- Documentation and escalation procedures
- Accountability for policy violations

Educators have the power to notice, respond, report, and help stop harm.

KNOW THE SIGNS. BE A SAFE ADULT. REPORT CONCERNS. SEEK MEANINGFUL TRAINING.

Sources: Wis. Stat. §§ 948.072, 948.098, 118.07(7), 48.981; Wisconsin DCF and DPI guidance.

TOGETHER, WE LIGHT UP THE DARKNESS.

Protecting children is everyone's responsibility.

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